

Monitoring, Evaluation & Reporting

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Q: Please provide information on evaluation either self-evaluation or by outside entity on RPTC work methods. If you have had, please provide recommendations emerging from those evaluations and your responses.

DESA is requested to provide the response based on the verbal responses from Mr. Harris.

DESA: The last review of the RPTC was conducted in 2004 following the request of the General Assembly in its resolution 58/270. The outcome of that review is contained in the Secretary-General's report A/59/397.

As indicated in that report, assessing the true development impact is a difficult task especially for the very small and short-term activities that characterize most interventions undertaken from RPTC resources. It is difficult to attribute results to every individual activity when the true impact measurement can only be reflected through progress identified through very broad macro indicators over an extended period.

Furthermore, OIOS conducted an audit of the management of the RPTC to assess its adequacy and effectiveness. The audit covered the period from January 2016 to December 2017. In response to a recommendation from the Audit of the management of the regular programme for technical cooperation by OIOS (OIOS report no. 2018/058; assignment no. AN2017/540/02), DESA is in the process of consulting with other implementing entities how to best assess to what extent RPTC as a whole is achieving its objectives with a view to increasing its effectiveness by drawing on lessons learnt over the last ten years and taking into consideration that the programme performance is included in the annual budget exercise pursuant to Resolution 72/266.

Nevertheless, entities have attempted to report on the impact of their interventions on an anecdotal basis in the Progress Report that is issued for most budget periods. The progress report for 2020 to facilitate discussions on the proposed programme budget by the Advisory Committee on Administrative and Budgetary Questions (ACABQ) in the context of its consideration of future budget submissions (A/68/7, para. V.107) will be prepared in 2021 and is expected to be completed by July 2021.

There was no progress report in 2019 because performance reporting was integrated into the overall proposed programme budget for RPTC (A/75/6 (Sect. 23) as a result of the introduction of the annual results framework, and in the related Supplementary information in keeping with resolution 72/266 A.

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Q: Noting that increases in travel requirements are shown in a number of programmes, what lessons learned and best practices were gathered that can be applied going forward

to reduce reliance on travel of staff

DESA is requested to provide the response based on the verbal responses from Mr. Harris.

In the last year, and sporadically before 2020, the entities have been able to convert and complement some of their in-person capacity development activities with digital equivalents.

Several eLearning programmes have been developed, including as prerequisite modules.

The uptake of digital tools and approaches have precipitated a shift in the UN approach to capacity development, providing an opportunity to design new delivery modalities using information technologies and e-learning, blended with traditional training modalities, to help realize the transformative change that the projects and activities set out to achieve.

The entities will be moving towards a hybrid approach of capacity development, combining in-person activities with virtual activities and complementing live (synchronous) sessions with independent (asynchronous) sessions.

Reviewing the achievements made in 2020 and 2021 to date, the advantages of e-learning can be summarized as follows:

Increased Flexibility (including time zones and times of day)

Cost-effective (reduced travel and accommodation cost)

Low Environmental Footprint (due to the nature of virtual sessions and the lack of travel, but also due to its wider reach and scalability)

Increased reach and scalability (virtual content can be easily shared and made accessible for wider audiences)

Analytical insights (statistics about attendance and demographics, what content was read, participation, quizzes, feedback survey etc.) can easily be extracted and aggregated.

Accessibility: Quality multilingual translations are possible in virtual formats.

Moving forward and into 2022, the entities will work to further integrate digital capacity development into their portfolio so that the recipients of capacity development and training activities will receive (and co-create) engaging, flexible, user-centred and highly effective capacity development support.

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Q: Regarding the support for economics and trade, please provide more information on the technical assistance provided through the RPTC to build trade by overcoming trade barriers.

9.1 ePing is a joint initiative of the UN, WTO and ITC. It was developed initially by DESA/Economic Analysis and Policy Division (RPTC/DESA SP6) in 2016, as a pilot version of assessments carried out in several LDCs which showed that public and private sector stakeholders were not accessing crucial

information contained in export product notifications in a timely manner. It also showed that in LDCs there is a general lack of information about product requirements, which often constitutes a barrier to trade. ePing helps to build capacity at the Government and also private sector to promote trade by addressing the information gaps in SPS and TBT regulation changes between destination markets and originating countries.

9.2 Country demand was determined based on an e-survey of all 46 LDCs, launched by the CDP Secretariat in collaboration with OHRLLS, at the LDC first PrepCom meeting on May 26, 2021. To avoid spreading too thin across numerous LDCs or attempting to cover too wide a range of areas and levels, the focus on Senegal and Zambia (reflected in T14 Development Account project ePing) is to adopt a strategic approach by focusing on graduating and graduated countries and selecting a few as project target countries.

9.3 Key to this approach is the notion that if DESA helps graduating countries effectively graduate and achieve sustainable and irreversible graduation, they, in turn, can develop the capacity/expertise to work with DESA to build the capacity of LDCs that follow after them or have yet to meet one of three graduation criteria.

9.4 The selection is directly linked to iGRAD (Sustainable Graduation Support Facility for LDCs) which is offered to countries meeting the LDC graduation criteria and in the following stages of graduation:

- a) graduating and recently graduated countries;
- b) countries recommended for graduation by the CDP but yet to be endorsed by ECOSOC;
- c) countries meeting the graduation criteria and under the CDP review; or
- d) countries who meet the graduation criteria in 2024 or 2027.

9.5 In addition to the country level survey, specific demand for ePing training was also conveyed through the Senegal and Zambia Enquiry Points.

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Q: Question 11. The increase in travel resource requirements is modest, why you do not use virtual whereby more persons can be trained?

6.1 Online consultations and virtual workshops cannot fully take the place of in-person meetings. Often in-person consultations are the only way to reach those left furthest behind that are not empowered to connect virtually, and might have difficulties in using digital technologies, are living in rural or remote areas and without easy access to WIFI/data and equipment that would be needed to work virtually, which is often expensive for them.

6.2 DESA and the other RPTC implementing entities closely monitor the feedback and success of all virtual activities, by assessing and evaluating learning outcomes and client feedback as well as by comparing costs/savings vis-à-vis in-person capacity development support. Based on the new data points generated, DESA will critically review whether, how and when it would be effective in the future to replace in-person activities with virtual ones. This assessment will take into consideration reported challenges relating to connectivity limitations, bandwidth as well as accessibility considerations and the need for multi-language servicing and simultaneous

interpretation.

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Q: Question 19. Please explain the methodology used to assess the short- medium- and long-term qualitative impact of the RPTC-funded projects on local level and how that information from implementing entities feeds into the overall reflection on management and the strategy for the fund.

11.1 It is important to apply a systems thinking approach when assessing the performance of the RPTC. Indeed, this funding source does not operate in isolation, as RPTC depends on the multiple other systems and contexts to ensure that its work is effective. Each implementing entity embeds the assessment of their work in their respective framework. For example, DESA requires filling out an Activity Proposal Template, which has 13 sections, including background describing the problem or need and connecting this information to: (a) the identified needs and priorities of the requesting government; and (b) the UN Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework. In keeping with the RPTC criteria, activities should fall within the priority areas, focusing on capacity development within developing countries. Upon completion of the activity, the responsible staff member completes a report that serves as basis for assessing the short-term impact of the intervention. The overall performance of the programme is assessed annually in the context of the progress report. The latest 7th Progress Report covered the period 2021.

11.2 As the RPTC interventions are usually small scale and short-term interventions, a systematic assessment of the long-term impact of the programme proves more difficult and is mainly pursued in the context of the impact of the respective subprogramme. As mentioned earlier, the RPTC does not operate in isolation, and its impact can best be assessed when embedded in the normative/analytical work of the subprogramme. For example, a legislative body such as the UN Statistics Commission may endorse a new methodology and requests the Secretariat to provide capacity development support to governments. The RPTC is then used to support governments, upon request, to apply such methodology in the national context. The Commission in subsequent sessions assesses the progress of the subprogramme, including progress in the use of the methodologies by Member Governments. Lessons learned usually feed into advice by the governing body on how to further improve the capacity development support by the secretariat.

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Q: What are the modalities and content of the workshops planned for 2020?

13.1 s indicated in the response to question 12 above, the modalities and content of the workshops for 2020 will depend on the

themes that will be identified for the HLPFs in July 2020 and July 2021. In general, subprogramme 3 distinguishes between thematically focused RPTC activities, with a focus on a specific theme, such as water, energy, oceans, climate change, and overarching, conceptual RPTC activities, such as the workshops on preparations of VNRs, workshops on institution building, workshops of monitoring of national development plans.

13.2 For example, in April 2019, DESA organized a workshop on 'stock-taking, lessons learned and opportunities for capacity building from the Voluntary National Reviews (VNRs). In this event, Member States, in particular developing countries, had an opportunity to express their capacity development needs for overarching activities in a global setting. In the remainder of 2019, the subprogramme will take the outcomes of this workshop and follow up at regional and sub-regional levels. Therefore, in 2020 the subprogramme expects to have a solid base of requests from individual countries. Some Member States have expressed the need to see more focus on interlinkages of SDGs and their implementation during the HLPF, and it is anticipated that this will also feed into capacity development demand. In addition to these, the subprogramme is also looking at capacity development needs expressed by SIDS in the context of the mid-term review of the SAMOA Pathway, which will take place in September 2019.

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